place in July 1943 on the Padang, a large open field that still exists at the heart of the city. There is a small memorial near the Singapore Cricket Club that marks the event. The original had been demolished by the British after the war, so the current memorial dates only from 1995. You are likely to encounter a few Indian tourists getting themselves photographed in front of it.

A twenty-minute walk will take you to Dhoby Ghat where Bose declared the formation of the Provisional Government of Free India. The proclamation was read out at the Cathay Cinema Hall. The building has been demolished, but a part of its façade has been preserved as part of a new shopping mall. Bose's army would fail in military terms alongside the defeat of its Japanese sponsors, but it fundamentally undermined the confidence of the British colonial government in the loyalties of its Indian troops. Although seven decades have passed, there are still a few Singaporean and Malaysian Indians alive who personally witnessed and participated in these events. I found it remarkable that these people, many of whom had been born in these parts and had never seen India, had been willing to die for the idea of a civilization.